

WEST BENGAL ORIGIN

Shukto

❀

Mixed Vegetable Stew with a Bitter Note
The First Course of a Bengali Meal

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Shukto

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Shukto

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Dish That Opens Every Bengali Feast

In the structure of a traditional Bengali meal, dishes arrive in a deliberate order, moving from light and bitter toward rich and sweet — and shukto is almost always the very first savory course, served just after rice, before anything richer touches the plate. Its defining note of gentle bitterness, usually from a few slices of bitter gourd (uchhe) or a bitter melon variety, is entirely intentional, believed in Bengali food tradition to awaken the palate and prepare the stomach for the courses that follow.

The dish brings together a striking mix of vegetables — often drumstick, potato, eggplant, plantain, and beans — bound in a pale, delicately spiced gravy built on a mustard-poppy seed paste and a touch of milk, finished with the fragrant five-spice blend panch phoron. Despite its many components, shukto is deliberately mild, its purpose being balance rather than boldness.

Shukto also carries ritual significance in many Bengali households, traditionally prepared during certain religious observances and considered an auspicious, purifying dish. Its combination of many vegetables in one pot has also made it a practical way to use up whatever the season offered, a resourceful dish born as much from thrift as from ceremony.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Dish That Opens Every Bengali Feast, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Traditionally the first savory course of a formal Bengali meal, served to awaken the palate before richer dishes follow. Considered an auspicious, purifying dish in many households, often prepared for religious observances and fasting-adjacent occasions. A dish that historically made resourceful use of whatever vegetables were seasonally available, cooked together in one pot. Rarely found on restaurant menus outside Bengal, making it a distinctly home-kitchen dish.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

20m	30m	4	Med
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Wide, heavy-bottomed kadai or pan
- Mortar and pestle or small blender, for the mustard-poppy seed paste
- Wooden spoon

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Shukto is traditionally best eaten fresh the day it's made, as its delicate, milk-based gravy doesn't reheat quite as gracefully as heavier curries. It keeps refrigerated for up to 2 days if needed — reheat gently over low heat, stirring frequently, without letting it boil hard.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the vegetables

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Bitter gourd (uchhe/karela), thinly sliced	1 small	80 g	1 small
Potato, cut into batons	1 medium	120 g	1 medium
Raw green banana (plantain), cut into batons	1	120 g	1
Drumstick (moringa), cut into 2-inch pieces	1	80 g	1
Eggplant, cut into batons	1 small	100 g	1 small
Flat beans or green beans, halved	1 cup	100 g	1 katori

For the paste & seasoning

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Mustard seeds	1 tbsp	10 g	1 chammach
Poppy seeds (posto)	1 tbsp	10 g	1 chammach
Ginger, roughly chopped	1 inch	10 g	1 inch
Panch phoron (Bengali five-spice blend)	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Bay leaf	1	1	1
Milk	½ cup	120 ml	½ katori
Ghee	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach
Mustard oil, for frying	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For the paste & seasoning (cont.)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Sugar	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Bitter gourd is essential to shukto's identity, but if you genuinely cannot find or tolerate it, a thin slice of neem leaf (used sparingly) or simply a slightly reduced quantity is a reasonable home adjustment — Bengali cooks themselves vary bitterness levels by household preference. Drumstick can be found frozen at South Asian grocers if fresh isn't available. Mustard oil gives shukto its distinctive pungent aroma; a neutral oil is a substitute, though the flavor will be noticeably milder and less traditional.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Paste and Vegetables

01 MAKE THE MUSTARD-POPPY PASTE

Soak the mustard seeds and poppy seeds in a little warm water for 15–20 minutes, then grind with the ginger to a smooth, pale paste using a mortar and pestle or small blender.

02 PREP THE VEGETABLES

Cut all the vegetables into similar-sized batons or pieces, so they cook evenly. Keep the bitter gourd separate, as it's fried on its own first.

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Preparing the Paste and Vegetables, continued



03 FRY THE BITTER GOURD

Heat mustard oil in a kadai and fry the bitter gourd slices until lightly golden and slightly crisp at the edges, about 3–4 minutes. Remove and set aside — frying it separately tempers its bitterness before it joins the rest of the dish.

Chef tip. frying the bitter gourd first, rather than adding it raw to the stew, is the traditional technique that keeps shukto's bitterness pleasant rather than overwhelming.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Paste and Vegetables, continued

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The mustard-poppy paste should be smooth with no gritty texture — take the time to grind thoroughly, as a coarse paste will make the finished gravy feel unrefined.

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Building the Stew

04 TEMPER THE PANCH PHORON

In the same kadai, add a little more mustard oil if needed and temper the panch phoron and bay leaf until fragrant, about 30 seconds.

05 ADD THE VEGETABLES

Add the potato, plantain, drumstick, eggplant, and beans, stirring to coat in the tempered oil. Cook for 5 minutes, then add enough water to just cover the vegetables and simmer until nearly tender, about 10–12 minutes.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Stew, continued

06 ADD THE PASTE AND MILK

Stir in the mustard-poppy paste, milk, sugar, and salt. Simmer gently for another 8–10 minutes, until the gravy thickens slightly and takes on a pale, creamy consistency.

Texture indicator. shukto's gravy should be thin and pale, coating the vegetables lightly rather than forming a thick sauce — it's meant to be a delicate broth, not a heavy curry.

07 ADD BACK THE BITTER GOURD

Return the fried bitter gourd to the pot, along with the ghee, and simmer for a final 2–3 minutes to bring everything together.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Boiling the milk-based gravy too vigorously can cause it to split. Keep the heat gentle once the milk goes in, and stir occasionally rather than letting it sit unattended at a hard boil.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served as the first course of a Bengali meal, immediately after plain rice, before any richer dishes.
- Eaten with a small portion of steamed rice, meant to be a light, palate-preparing course rather than a filling one.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a small bowl, often a traditional bell-metal (kansa) vessel, as the opening course of a Bengali thali.

Family Style

- Served in individual small bowls at the start of the meal, before the table moves on to dal and vegetable dishes.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Balance Right

- Frying the bitter gourd separately, rather than boiling it with everything else, is the key technique for a pleasant, rounded bitterness.
- A touch of sugar is essential — shukto should taste subtly sweet-bitter-savory all at once, not purely bitter.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The mustard-poppy paste can be made a day ahead and refrigerated, saving time on the day of cooking.
- Shukto is best made fresh close to serving time, given its delicate milk-based gravy.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some Bengali households add a small piece of radish or a few slices of raw papaya for extra texture and subtle sweetness — a traditional variation worth trying if you enjoy the dish's complexity.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

150 kcal	4 g	20 g	7 g	6 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Doi Shukto	a version finished with a spoonful of yogurt for extra tang.
Shukto with Fish Head (Machher Matha Diye Shukto)	a non-vegetarian variation using fish head for extra depth, popular in some households.
Simplified Shukto	a quicker home version using fewer vegetables when a full traditional mix isn't available.

Can I make shukto without bitter gourd?

It's possible, though bitter gourd is central to the dish's identity — even a small amount, fried well, is worth including if you can find it.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why is my shukto too watery?

The gravy is meant to be thin and light, but if it feels too watery, simmer a little longer uncovered to reduce and thicken slightly.

Is shukto served as a main course?

No — traditionally it's a starter course in a multi-dish Bengali meal, eaten in a small portion before richer dal and vegetable dishes follow.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Panch Phoron	a Bengali five-spice blend of mustard, fennel, cumin, fenugreek, and nigella seeds.
Uchhe	a variety of bitter gourd specifically used in Bengali cooking.
Posto	Bengali for poppy seeds, ground into a paste for this dish's gravy.
Kansa	traditional Bengali bell metal, often used for serving dishes like shukto.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Shukto

20m	30m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	Med
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

VEGETABLES

Bitter gourd	80 g
Potato	120 g
Raw green banana	120 g
Drumstick	80 g
Eggplant	100 g
Flat beans or green beans	100 g

PASTE & SEASONING

Mustard seeds	10 g
Poppy seeds	10 g
Ginger	10 g
Panch phoron	3 g
Bay leaf	1
Milk	120 ml
Ghee	15 g
Mustard oil	45 ml
Sugar	4 g
Salt	6 g

METHOD

01 **Make the mustard-poppy paste.** Soak the mustard seeds and poppy seeds in a little warm water for 15–20 minutes, then grind with the ginger to a smooth, pale paste using a mortar and pestle or small blender.

02 **Prep the vegetables.** Cut all the vegetables into similar-sized batons or pieces, so they cook evenly.

03 **Fry the bitter gourd.** Heat mustard oil in a kadai and fry the bitter gourd slices until lightly golden and slightly crisp at the edges, about 3–4 minutes.

04 **Temper the panch phoron.** In the same kadai, add a little more mustard oil if needed and temper the panch phoron and bay leaf until fragrant, about 30 seconds.

05 **Add the vegetables.** Add the potato, plantain, drumstick, eggplant, and beans, stirring to coat in the tempered oil.

06 **Add the paste and milk.** Stir in the mustard-poppy paste, milk, sugar, and salt.

07 **Add back the bitter gourd.** Return the fried bitter gourd to the pot, along with the ghee, and simmer for a final 2–3 minutes to bring everything together.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐	Bitter gourd	80 g	
☐	Raw green banana	120 g	
☐	Eggplant	100 g	
☐	Mustard seeds	10 g	
☐	Ginger	10 g	
☐	Bay leaf	1	
☐	Ghee	15 g	
☐	Sugar	4 g	
☐	Potato	120 g	
☐	Drumstick	80 g	
☐	Flat beans or green beans	100 g	
☐	Poppy seeds	10 g	
☐	Panch phoron	3 g	
☐	Milk	120 ml	
☐	Mustard oil	45 ml	
☐	Salt	6 g	

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